family, wasn’t it appropriate for the two of us to address them as Jack and Nelle? They were probably a little shocked at first, but they consented to it, and after a while I think they liked the special familiarity it gave the four of us.

In high school, my brother had a teammate on the football team, Winston McReynolds, who was his closest buddy and they were so inseparable the other players began referring to Neil as “Moon” and Winston as “Mushmouth”—the names of the two lead characters in the “Moon Mullins” comic strip.

Neil’s nickname stuck and, from then on, about the only person who ever called him Neil was my mother.

When I entered Dixon High School in 1924, I was thirteen and worshiped football more than anything else in the world. I wanted desperately to play for the school team. The fact that my brother was already a star on the team only intensified my resolve.

Although it fielded only a single football team, Dixon High had recently been divided into two campuses on opposite sides of town, the Northside and the Southside campuses.

Our family had just moved to the north side of Dixon. As a freshman, I was assigned to the Northside campus, but Moon decided to remain with his classmates at the Southside school. It was probably fortunate for me that he did. Although he and I were close, he was still my older—and bigger—brother, and we had our share of brotherly fistfights and rivalries. He had always had an outspoken, self-confident personality that was a little like Jack’s, which made him a natural leader, and until then I think I probably felt a little under his shadow. On my own at Northside, I knew I wouldn’t have to be compared with him.

As the trees in the Rock River Valley began turning gold that fall, I joined a large group of other boys on the grassy field where for years I’d watched my heroes play football, ready to compete for the right to wear a purple and white jersey.